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Encore at London

Beijing proves we must equip and support our athletes with the best

The giant took its first baby step in 2008 and won its first individual Olympic gold in Beijing. After Beijing, the questions around Indian sport have shown a shift. In London we will not wonder "whether" India can win gold but rather "how many?" For the first time, Indian athletes received well-deserved attention and support during an Olympic year.

The athletes were quick to respond and their results speak for themselves. It is noteworthy that our medal-winners at the Beijing Olympics came from the extreme ends of the economic and social spectrum. If India is to succeed consistently in future, the need is for the right systems and incentives to encourage talented youngsters across social strata to participate in and achieve excellence in sports. And just to reinforce the general positive atmosphere that surrounds the Indian growth story, most of India's top sporting performers are still very young and are yet to achieve their full potential.

For the first time, I also noticed that the words—"world-class" and "professionalism" had crept into our sporting lingo. Everyone from administrators to athletes used these words repeatedly and that, in itself, has a way of reinforcing belief and demanding the best from all stakeholders in the system. As someone who remains deeply entrenched in the Indian sporting system, I have observed the natural consequences of this change in attitude: there is a growing demand for sports-dedicated professionals—nutritionists, psychologists, fitness trainers, coaches, managers and sports-marketing agents—with a vision that is beyond cricket.

India is probably a couple of decades behind the rest of the world when it comes to sports in general. But with positive moves being made this year, along with access to modern applications, we have the opportunity to leapfrog to parity and beyond. The Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports has shown its intentions: besides giving unprecedented support to elite athletes, the Ministry has also initiated programmes at the grassroots through village panchayats to broadbase sports. As long as the quality of execution is not compromised, these will go a long way towards creating a healthy sporting culture. In times of difficulty—economic or social—sporting achievement can be the social glue that brings a nation together. Our best athletes are our modern-day warriors. They have the capacity to inspire change and bring pride. We must equip them well to meet all possible challenges when they represent the country. With the right support, it will not be too long before baby steps become large strides and these strides, in turn, convert to sporting dominance.

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AFP



INDIA HAD A GLORIOUS YEAR WITH ODI SERIES WINS IN AUSTRALIA AND SRI LANKA

ing's profile and confidence has surged like a torrential stream, with four fighters returning from the recent World Cup in Moscow with medals.

If 2008 was a year of transformation for Indian sport, Indian cricket, which usually functions in a distant, alternate universe, has also been touched by the breezes of fundamental change. Even though the Peter Pan called Sachin Tendulkar continued to reinvent himself and surprise us, this was the year two of his comrades from the Golden Generation, Anil Kumble and Sourav Ganguly, quit the playfield. India will have to prepare itself for more departures of its greatest-ever clutch of Test cricketers.

Such a constellation will never gather again because it is the short game that has India in thrall. The T20 revolution and the success of the first Indian Premier League (IPL) could alter the economics of the game and with it, India's priorities.

The 2009 IPL will be tempered in the wake of the global meltdown and the renewed rift between India and Pakistan. Should it stay afloat, its influence in the future cannot be discounted.

On the field, the Indian team found a rare and fine balance this year: playing two virtually dissimilar teams under two different captains and still putting up a combined front. They finished the year with a 6-4 win loss record from 15 Tests and a staggering 19-8 record in 29 ODIs. One-day series wins in Australia and Sri Lanka reflected on the growing authority and acumen of its captain M.S. Dhoni. Yet little else spoke more eloquently for Dhoni than his generous public conduct during the departures of Kumble and Ganguly. He will face greater trials in the future but he carries with him confidence, goodwill, good fortune and a team coming into the best shape of its life—factors that make his prickly job that bit simpler.

If any other man carried his labours as lightly as Dhoni does these days, it must be golfer Jeev Milkha